

Communities which rely on agriculture need strong networks and local leaders. This is important in helping to build drought resilience.

That's why the Future Drought Fund is investing in the Communities Program, with [\\$36 million in funding over 4 years \(2024-2028\)](#).

The Future Drought has worked in partnership with the [Foundation for Rural & Regional Renewal \(FRRR\)](#) and the [Australian Rural Leadership Foundation \(ARLF\)](#) since 2021. The Communities Program builds on previous programs, including the Helping Regional Communities Prepare for Drought Initiative.

The Communities Program will continue to support and develop leaders, as well as build and support networks and organisations. This will occur in remote, rural and regional agriculture-dependent communities.

FRRR and ARLF will help deliver the Communities Program across 5 program elements (details below).

Program Elements

Community Impact Program (CIP)

Delivered by FRRR and ARLF: Grants will be used for implementation of social resilience activities in Regional Drought Resilience Plans (RDRPs), which may be further refined through the CIP co-design process. Each CIP region will also have access to a suite of leadership activities (coaching, training, and other support) from ARLF.

Regional Drought Resilience Plan (RDRP) Social Outcome Grants program

Delivered by FRRR: Grants to support activities that help deliver social resilience activities in RDRPs. Up to 50 regions are to receive grants.

Small Network Grants

Delivered by FRRR: Grants for projects to build social resilience to drought across several funding rounds. Areas which do not have an RDRP are encouraged to apply.

National Mentoring Initiative

Delivered by ARLF: This initiative will pair an experienced mentor with a mentee over a 12-month period. Knowledge sharing will occur, and participants will undertake tailored learning opportunities.

Capacity Building Initiative

Delivered by FRRR: This initiative will aim to strengthen community not-for-profit organisations in agriculture-dependent communities with a focus on those with limited access to specialist expertise. This initiative will also look to upskill or support regions depending on their individual needs.

More information on the FDF Communities Program

More information is provided by our delivery partners:

Previous programs

Helping Regional Communities Prepare for Drought Initiative

Delivered by FRRR and ARLF. The Initiative consisted of 5 elements, and delivered positive and tangible benefits to agriculture dependent communities across the country.

The contracted Nous Group worked in partnership with delivery partners. It assessed the impact of the Future Drought Fund's Helping Regional Communities Prepare for Drought Initiative. Nous Group prepared the [mid-term evaluation report](#), released October 2024. The report confirmed good progress was being made towards strengthening social resilience. A final evaluation report for the Initiative will be available at the end of 2025.

National Learning Network

Delivered by ARLF. The [Drought Ready Network](#) connected individuals and organisations to learn from one another. It launched in 2023.

Networks to Build Drought Resilience

- 87 community groups completed projects creating or strengthening local networks
- 791 activities reached 37,841 regional Australians.

Drought Resilience Leaders

618 regional Australians from 474 towns strengthened their community resilience to drought. They did this by participating in the:

- Drought Leadership Development courses
- Community Extension Grants
- Drought Resilience Leaders Mentoring Program

See the impact on participants from Western Australia's Northern Wheatbelt.

[Music]

Julie Freeman, Director Redbrae Farms, Mullewa, WA

I came to Mullewa as a graduate school teacher and when you're new to Town the best way to get to know people is to get involved.

There comes a point particularly in a small community where if you've got some skills that are useful people start turning to you to ask for help and that's when you really start to think about leadership.

What the drought resilience leadership program gave to me was a really clear picture of how expansive my role could be in this community.

Climate change and increasing temperatures are going to have an impact on the frequency and the severity of drought. If we have really strong social connections in the community then I think we can weather most storms.

I think my impact's only just beginning. Building that social cohesion and building that vision of who we want to be and working towards it, it's like putting something in reserve for when things get tough and and that's what I'll be able to contribute to over the next couple of years.

Rural Australia is super important to achieving climate change action. This is where the wind farms and the solar farms and the green hydrogen's all going to happen - out here - so I want people to really appreciate the value in investing in us.

I think the journey is just beginning.

Milton Milloy, Area Manager Midwest Gascoyne, Mission Australia, Geraldton, WA

I was born in Morawa, my father was born in Morawa and my grandparents came out to Morawa from Scotland very early in the 1900s.

I lived through the droughts when I was a young child and I watched my parents go through it and struggle through it.

The challenges around drought not only affects the farmers and their income, the ongoing challenge with community is then there's not as much employment going on, there's not as much money circulating within the community; repercussions of that are massive, like dropping a rock in in a pond - the ripple goes out and out and out and affects more than just the farmers.

I've always believed good leadership's always going to make good communities, good teams. The drought resilience leadership course actually showed me that there's lots of different ways to lead and you've got to be open to change to make good leaders.

There's a lot of people in these small country towns that I don't think are being recognized, that they're really struggling through life, so the programs and the work I'll do moving forward will be developing programs to stop people being in struggle street, and getting up on their feet.

Part of being resilient is being able to recognize that that change needs to happen quickly and not wait, because if you wait, you may miss the moment.

Funding information

Payment information below for the Communities Program. As required under section 27A of the Future Drought Fund Act 2019.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/drought/future-drought-fund/helping-regional-communities-prepare-for-drought-initiative>